NewsBank inc.

Meeting in LV will focus on U.S.-Israeli ties

September 18, 2003 | Las Vegas Sun (NV)
Section: News | 606 Words
OpenURL Link

The head of this country's leading pro-Israel lobby said there will not be peace between Israelis and Palestinians until Palestinian leader Yasser Arafat is removed.

Howard Kohr, executive director of the American Israel Public Affairs Committee in Washington, said that point is certain to be raised on Sunday, when the group holds its first annual dinner at The Venetian. The event will focus on the value of a strong relationship between the United States and Israel.

Kohr said in a telephone interview Wednesday that Arafat remains a major impediment to peace. When asked if Arafat ought to be assassinated, an option Israeli government officials have said they would consider, Kohr said AIPAC has not take a position on the method of "removal."

"Arafat is committed to terrorism and committed to incitement against Israel," Kohr said. "He has to be removed. The way of removal is for the world community and for Israel to consider."

Kohr held out hope that the Bush administration's "road map for peace" can still be achieved despite continued violence in Israel.

"The president on June 24 laid out a very important vision, a vision that laid out the direction of peace between Israel and the the Palestinians," Kohr said.

He said that vision includes the belief that Palestinian leaders must denounce terrorism.

"That does not yet appear to be the case," Kohr said.

A security fence has been erected by Israel to protect some of its communities from Palestinian towns in the West Bank. Although some critics have suggested the fence is not needed, Kohr disagreed and said the only controversy is the location of the fence.

"As long as Arafat is committed to terrorism the terrorism will continue," Kohr said. "Until the Palestinians are willing to take on the terrorist organizations, the people of Israel are forced with hard choices. How do they defend themselves?"

Kohr expressed pleasure at the decision by the United States to help freeze assets belonging to Hamas, the Palestinian terrorist group that has been responsible for many of the fatal bombings in Israel. He said AIPAC was hopeful that European nations would follow suit and freeze Hamas assets as well.

On a related topic, Kohr said the United States needs to apply more pressure on Syria to stop the shipment of arms from Iran to the Hezbollah, another terrorist group that is based in Lebanon. Kohr said one way to apply pressure is through support of the Syrian Accountability Act, which is working its way through Congress and has the support of 74 senators, including Sen. John Ensign, R-Nev., and Senate Minority Whip Harry Reid, D-Nev.

"The U.S. needs to get far more serious with Syria," Kohr said.

Kohr said one purpose of Sunday's dinner is to thank Nevada's congressional delegation for its support of AIPAC. That sentiment was shared by event co-chairman Paul Bodner, owner of an executive search consulting firm in Las Vegas.

"Our state delegation for many years has been terrifically responsive to pro-Israel issues and has been supportive of AIPAC," Bodner said. "They understand the need to support Israel as a democracy."

The formal title of the dinner is "America and Israel: Politically United ... Emotionally Tied."

Resort owners Dr. Miriam and Sheldon Adelson, leading financial contributors to Israel, will serve as honorary chairpeople of the event, which is expected to draw 300 people. Barbara and Brian Greenspun, members of the family that publishes the Las Vegas Sun, are host committee members for the dinner.

Speakers will include Ensign, Rep. Jon Porter, R-Nev., Rep. Anthony Weiner, D-N.Y., Ester Kurz, AIPAC's top lobbyist, and student Jesse Gabriel, immediate past president of the student body at the University of California, Berkeley.

Copyright 2003 Greenspun Media Group, Las Vegas Sun. All Rights Reserved.

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Meeting in LV will focus on U.S.-Israeli ties. (2003, September 18).*Las Vegas Sun (NV)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1326E1A0186B7ED0.